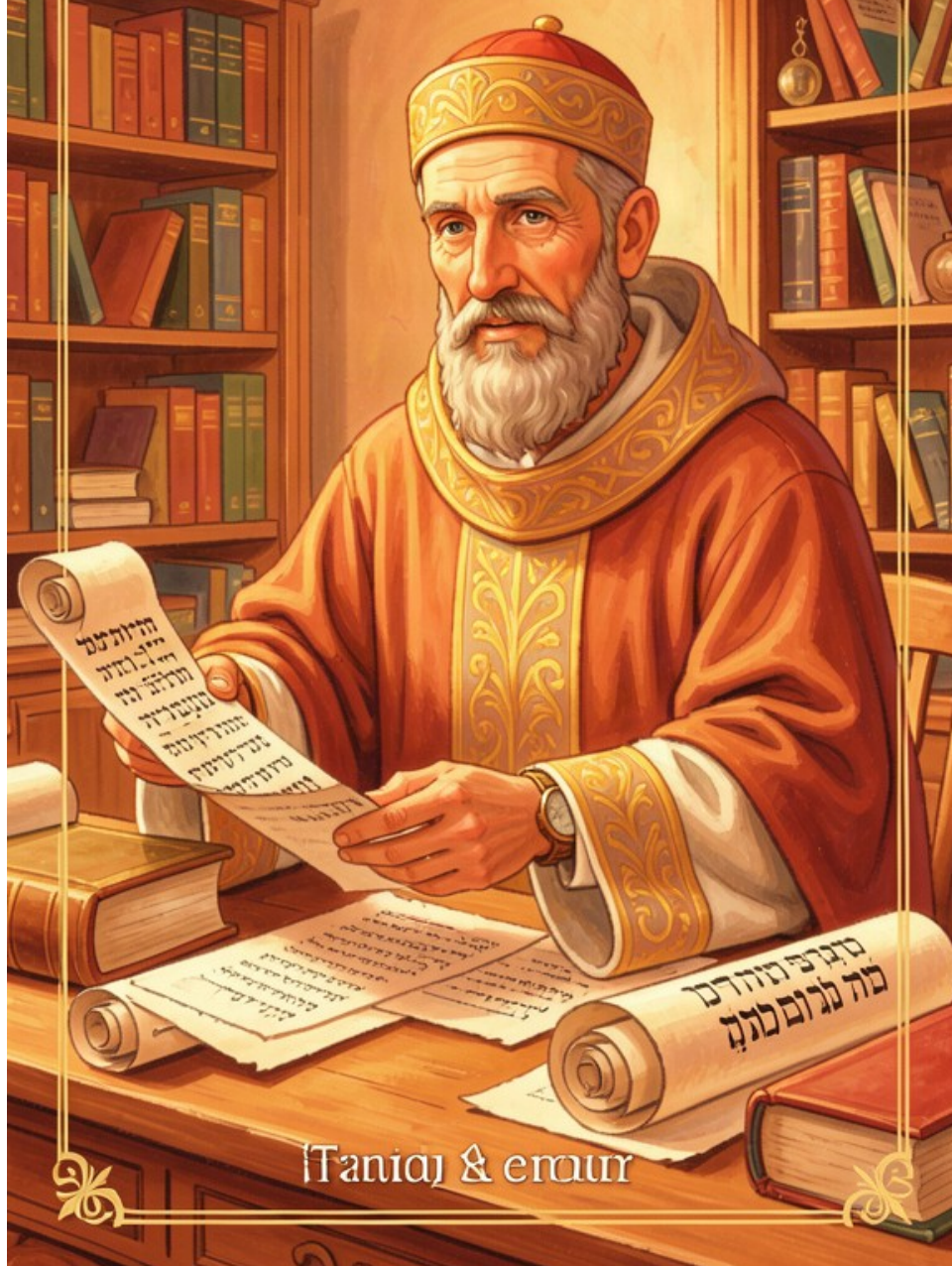


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The Man Who Gave Words to God's Book

WisdomForge Booklet — Ages 5–10

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About This Book

Have you ever played the game called Telephone? You whisper a sentence to the person next to you, and they whisper it to the next person, and by the time it reaches the end of the line, the words have changed? Maybe "The cat sat on the mat" turns into "The bat sat on the hat." Everyone laughs because the message got mixed up along the way.

Now imagine that the message is the most important book in the world, and it has been whispered through many languages and many hundreds of years. Some words got changed. Some got lost. Some people memorized the wrong version without knowing it.

This is the story of a man named Jerome who noticed the problem and decided to fix it. He lived a long, long time ago — more than fifteen hundred years before you were born — in a world without computers, printing presses, or even paper as we know it. He learned three languages, lived in a desert cave, argued with popes and bishops, and spent his whole life making sure the Bible said what it was supposed to say.

He was brilliant. He was also grumpy, impatient, and sometimes mean to people who disagreed with him. He was a real person — not a perfect hero from a story, but a complicated man who did something extraordinary. His story teaches us about words, about truth, about the courage to fix mistakes, and about the hard question of whether being right gives you the right to be unkind.

Chapter 1: Every Translation Is a Choice — Jerome and the Sun That Shines



Illustration for Chapter 1

Imagine you are standing outside on a bright morning. You want to tell someone what you see. In English, you might say, "The sun shines." In another language, people might say, "The sun gives light." In yet another, they might say, "The sun is warm on my face." All three sentences describe the same sun, but each one paints a slightly different picture.

Which one is right? They all are. But they are not the same.

This was the first big idea that Jerome discovered: when you move words from one language to another, you have to make choices. You cannot just swap each word for its match, like replacing puzzle pieces. Languages are not identical codes. They divide the world differently. They carry different habits, different sounds, different ways of seeing.

Jerome figured this out more than a thousand years before anyone used the word "translation theory." He was born around 347 CE in a small town called Stridon, in a place we now call Croatia. His family had enough money to send him to the big city of Rome for school. There he learned to read and write beautiful Latin, the language spoken across the Roman Empire. He read the great Roman writers — Cicero, Virgil, Horace — and fell in love with the sound of well-made sentences.

But Jerome was also a Christian. He believed the Bible was God's word. And the Bible was not written in Latin. The Old Testament was mostly written in Hebrew. The New Testament was written in Greek. Latin speakers read translations, and those translations were messy. Different towns had different versions. Some were clear; some were confusing. Some had mistakes that had been copied and recopied for hundreds of years.

When Jerome began translating, he made a decision that sounded simple but was actually bold. He decided to translate the *meaning*, not just the words. He said it this way:

"I have interpreted not word for word, but sense for sense."

What did he mean? He meant that if a Hebrew sentence naturally describes the sun as "shining," and Latin needs a different construction to say the same thing, the translator should choose the natural Latin expression. Otherwise the reader gets a sentence that is formally faithful but sounds dead.

Jerome gave an example in his *Commentary on Matthew*:

"The same sense is not always expressed by the same words. For who, when about to describe the sun, would not rather say 'the sun shines' than 'the sun is illuminated'?"

Think about that. "The sun shines" and "the sun is illuminated" mean almost the same thing. But the first sounds alive. The second sounds like a textbook. Jerome wanted the Bible to sound alive.

Not everyone agreed. Some people believed that every word of Scripture was sacred, and changing even the form of a sentence felt like breaking something holy. Jerome's critics accused him of taking liberties with God's word. But Jerome believed that the meaning was what mattered most, and meaning sometimes requires changing the shape of the sentence.

Every time you read a translated book, a subtitled movie, or instructions in two languages, you are meeting Jerome's problem. Someone had to choose. The choice is small, but it is real. And Jerome was one of the first people to say so out loud.

Words to Remember

*"I have interpreted not word for word, but sense for sense." — Jerome, *Preface to the Gospels**

This means: when you move a story from one language to another, you try to keep the meaning, even if you have to change the words.

*"The same sense is not always expressed by the same words." — Jerome, *Commentary on Matthew**

This means: two sentences can mean the same thing even if they use different words.

Big Idea

Every translation is a choice. When you move words from one language to another, you cannot copy them exactly. You have to decide what matters most — the exact words, or the meaning behind them. Jerome chose meaning. That choice shaped how people read the Bible for over a thousand years.

Try This

1. **The Sun Game.** Write one sentence about something you see outside. Now rewrite it three different ways without changing what it describes. Which version do you like best?
2. **Telephone Translation.** Whisper a sentence to a friend. They whisper it to the next. The last person says it out loud. Did it change? Talk about where the words shifted.
3. **Same Meaning, Different Words.** Think of the word "happy." Write five words that mean something close — joyful, glad, cheerful, delighted, content. Do they all feel exactly the same? That is what a translator thinks about.

Ask a Grown-Up

Can you think of a time when you had to explain something and the other person understood different words but got the same meaning? How did you know they understood you?

Chapter 2: The Oldest Story — Jerome Goes Back to the Source



Illustration for Chapter 2

Imagine a long chain of people, each one whispering a story to the next. The first person heard the original story. The second person heard the first person's version. The third heard the second's. By the time the story reaches the tenth person, it may have changed a little — or a lot.

Now ask: which person is most likely to have the story right? The first one, who heard it from the beginning? Or the tenth one, who heard it through many whispers?

Jerome said the first one. And for the Old Testament part of the Bible, the "first one" meant the Hebrew original.

Here is the problem he faced. By Jerome's time, most Christians outside the land of Israel read their Old Testament in Greek, in a version called the Septuagint. The Septuagint was translated from Hebrew into Greek about three hundred years before Jesus was born. A famous story said that seventy-two Jewish scholars had been locked in separate rooms and all produced identical translations — a miracle proving that God had guided their work.

Many Christians believed the Septuagint was not just a translation but an inspired text, directly blessed by God. To question it felt like questioning Scripture itself.

Jerome questioned it. He said: the Septuagint is a translation. Translations can have mistakes. The Hebrew text is older. It is the language in which these books were first written. No translation, no matter how beloved, can be more reliable than its source.

He is reported to have said something bold and a little cheeky:

"If I were to believe that the Holy Spirit was the author only of the Septuagint and not of the Hebrew text, I would have to conclude that the Holy Spirit had lost his tongue."

What he meant was: if God inspired the Bible, God inspired the Hebrew original. The Greek translation came later. To treat the translation as uniquely inspired while ignoring the original was, in Jerome's view, to prefer a copy over the source.

This was not a popular position. People worried that if Jerome translated from Hebrew, he might change readings that Christians had used for centuries. They worried that Jewish interpreters, who knew Hebrew, might influence Christian Scripture. They worried that familiar words in worship would disappear.

Augustine, one of the greatest thinkers of the church, wrote to Jerome with concern. He did not deny that Jerome's Hebrew-based translation might be more accurate. He worried about ordinary believers hearing a text they knew suddenly changed. Would they think the church had changed its faith?

Jerome's answer was simple, maybe too simple: truth is worth the disruption. He acknowledged that people dislike new translations. He simply believed that accuracy mattered more than comfort.

But Jerome was not as extreme as people sometimes thought. He did not reject the Septuagint entirely. He produced two Latin versions of the Psalms — one from the Greek Septuagint (called the Gallican Psalter) and one from the Hebrew (called the Hebraic Psalter). The Gallican Psalter became the standard Psalms used in church worship for centuries. So Jerome used and valued the Septuagint too. His point was that the Hebrew should be the court of final appeal when the versions disagreed.

His preference anticipated modern scholarship by more than a thousand years. Today's Hebrew Bible scholars work primarily from the Masoretic Text, compare it with the Dead Sea Scrolls and ancient translations, and treat the Septuagint as one important witness — not as the original. Jerome's instinct — go back to the source — turned out to be right.

Words to Remember

"If I were to believe that the Holy Spirit was the author only of the Septuagint and not of the Hebrew text, I would have to conclude that the Holy Spirit had lost his tongue."
— Jerome

This means: God inspired the original Hebrew, not just a later Greek translation of it.

*"I have translated the Book of Psalms not, as some suppose, from the Septuagint, but from the Hebrew itself, into Latin." — Jerome, *Preface to the Psalter**

This means: Jerome went back to the oldest version to get the most accurate text.

Big Idea

When you want to know what a story really says, go back to the oldest version. Jerome believed the Hebrew text was more reliable than the Greek translation because it was older and closer to the original. This was a brave choice because many people loved the old translation and did not want it changed.

Try This

1. The Chain Story. Tell a short story to a friend. Have them tell it to the next person, and the next. The last person tells it to everyone. Compare it to your original. The first version is like the Hebrew — closest to the source.

2. Old and New. Ask a grown-up to show you an old family recipe or photograph. Do you think the oldest version is always the most accurate? Can you think of when it might not be?

3. **Be the Detective.** Imagine two copies of your favorite book had different words on the same page. How would you figure out which was right?

Ask a Grown-Up

Have you ever found out that something you believed for a long time was not quite right? How did you feel when you learned the truth? Did you change your mind, or did you want to keep believing the old way?

Chapter 3: The Difficult Genius — Jerome's Sharp Tongue

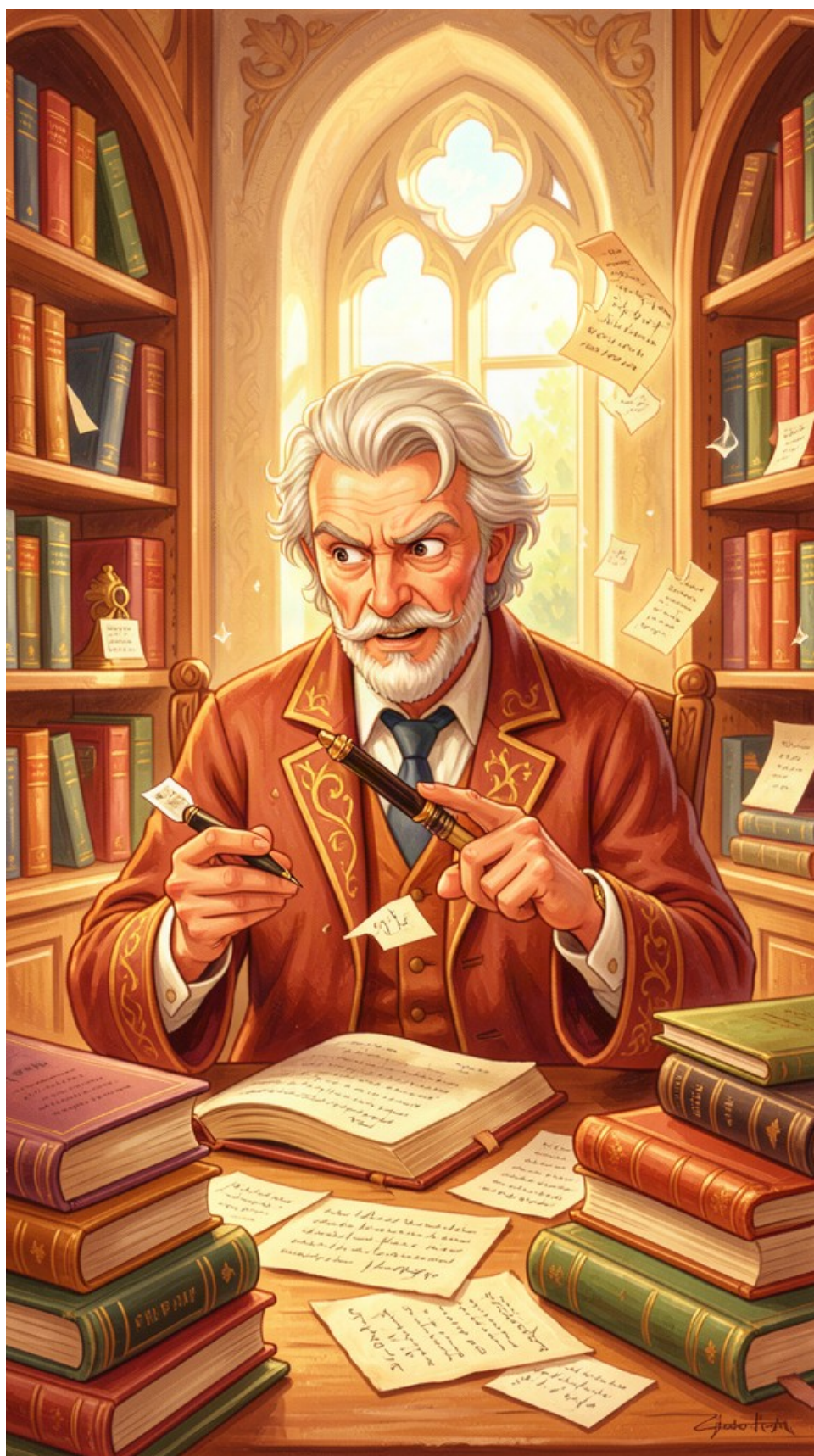


Illustration for Chapter 3

Some people are brilliant and kind. Some people are brilliant and difficult. Jerome was brilliant and difficult.

If you read his letters — and many of them survive — you can feel his personality jumping off the page. He was sarcastic. He was impatient. He could wound a friend with a sentence and then, a few letters later, write with such tenderness that you wanted to forgive him.

He knew he was smart. He had mastered three languages — Latin, Greek, and Hebrew — at a time when most scholars managed two poorly. He had read more widely than almost anyone he knew. He had worked directly from ancient manuscripts. He was right about many things that others had not yet seen.

That confidence was justified. It was also a problem. Jerome found it hard to be patient with people who were not as smart as he was. When Augustine, a great thinker himself, asked a question Jerome thought was too simple, Jerome corrected his Greek and dismissed the point. When Rufinus, once his closest friend, challenged him, Jerome replied with insults as well as arguments. When a man named Jovinian said that marriage was just as good as being single, Jerome compared married people to animals.

He was not a simple villain. The same man who attacked opponents with glee also wrote movingly to friends about grief and love. His letter about the death of his friend Marcella is a real memorial, full of tenderness. He wept over deaths, remembered kindnesses, and supported the communities he had helped build. He was capable of love and loyalty.

But his sharpness cost him. Some people who might have learned from him were pushed away. Some opponents who might have become allies became enemies. His tone sometimes distracted from his arguments — people remembered the insult longer than the point.

There is a lesson here, and it is one Jerome himself did not always follow. Being right does not give you the right to be cruel. A true thing can be said kindly, and saying it cruelly may stop people from hearing it. Confidence is not the same as contempt. You can believe you are right without despising everyone who disagrees.

Jerome's temper also had a hidden side. His sharpness was not pure arrogance. It was also insecurity. He wanted recognition. He resented slights. He measured himself against rivals and felt the comparison keenly. When his scholarship was questioned, he felt that *he* was being questioned. A more secure person might have answered a critic with a correction. Jerome answered with everything he had.

Modern readers should not try to diagnose him. We do not have enough evidence, and it would be unfair. But we can notice the pattern: the same fire that drove him to do brilliant

work also burned the people around him. The gift and the flaw were tangled together, as they often are in real people.

Words to Remember

"I am confident that the truth, when it is once known, will please all who love learning." — Jerome, to Augustine

This means: Jerome believed that if people learned what was true, they would accept it. He did not always understand why they resisted.

*"I cannot bear those who presume to teach what they have not learned." — Jerome, *Letter 53**

This means: Jerome had no patience for people who taught things they did not understand. He could have said this more gently.

Big Idea

Being good at something does not give you permission to be unkind. Jerome was one of the smartest people of his time, but his sharp tongue hurt friendships and made enemies. The strongest arguments come from people who can state their opponent's view fairly, not from people who mock it.

Try This

1. **Rewrite the Insult.** Think of a time someone was mean to you. Rewrite what they said so it is firm but not cruel. Does the message get through better or worse?
2. **The Strength and the Weakness.** Think of someone who is very good at something. Write down one way their talent helps people and one way it causes problems.
3. **Anger to Sorrow.** Think of something that frustrates you. Instead of writing an angry sentence, write a sad one. How does the feeling change?

Ask a Grown-Up

Have you ever met someone who was very smart but not very nice? Did you want to learn from them, or did their attitude make you want to stay away? What would you say to them if you could?

Chapter 4: Three Languages — The Boy Who Learned Words No One Else Knew



Illustration for Chapter 4

Jerome believed that if you wanted to understand the Bible truly, you needed to know three languages: Latin, Greek, and Hebrew.

Latin was his first language — the language of the Western church and of his own translation work. Greek was the language of the New Testament and of the old Greek translation of the Old Testament. Hebrew was the language in which most of the Old Testament was first written.

If you knew only Latin, you depended on whatever translation you happened to have. If you knew Greek too, you could read the New Testament and the Greek Old Testament, but not the Hebrew original. Only someone who knew all three could move freely across the whole world of the Bible.

Jerome said this most clearly in a letter to a man named Paulinus, who wanted to study the Bible seriously. He wrote:

"We must read first of all the divine Scriptures; but we must read them through the medium of the Old Latin translation, the Old Greek, and the original Hebrew. Let the student be possessed with a proper fear of God and not seek after the praises of men. Let him not teach what he has not learned. Let him learn what he is to teach."

Notice what Jerome did there. He did not just say "learn three languages." He connected knowledge to character. The student must approach Scripture with reverence and humility. The student must learn before teaching. Languages are tools, but tools must be used by the right kind of person.

Learning Hebrew was Jerome's hardest challenge. For a Latin-speaking Christian in the fourth century, Hebrew was not an obvious language to learn. Its alphabet, grammar, and vocabulary were completely different from Latin or Greek. Most Christian scholars simply avoided it. Hebrew was associated with Jews, and many Christians were suspicious of Jewish teachers.

Jerome went ahead anyway. He learned Hebrew from a Jewish teacher, probably in the Syrian desert, living in a cave and eating simply. He was not a young student. He was an adult with an established education, learning a new language from scratch in harsh conditions. He had no dictionary, no grammar book, no app. He had manuscripts, a teacher, and his own determination.

His Hebrew was probably not perfect. Modern scholars debate how fluent he really was. But even imperfect Hebrew gave him access that almost none of his rivals had. He could compare the Hebrew text with the Greek and Latin versions. He could ask Jewish

interpreters about difficult words. He could judge for himself whether older translations had gotten a passage right.

The three-language ideal — the *vir trilinguis*, the "trilingual man" — became a standard for Christian scholarship. Medieval monasteries taught Latin. The Renaissance later recovered Greek and Hebrew. Protestant reformers insisted that ministers should know the biblical languages. Modern seminaries still require Greek and Hebrew for biblical studies students. Jerome's idea lived on in every student who opens a Hebrew lexicon or parses a Greek verb.

But Jerome knew that knowing languages alone was not enough. A linguist can be morally shallow. A humble reader with a good translation may understand more than a proud scholar with perfect Hebrew. That is why Jerome paired the language requirement with warnings about reverence and humility. The tools are only as good as the person who uses them.

Words to Remember

*"We must read first of all the divine Scriptures; but we must read them through the medium of the Old Latin translation, the Old Greek, and the original Hebrew." — Jerome, *Letter 53**

This means: the serious student needs access to the Bible in all three of its languages.

*"Let him not teach what he has not learned. Let him learn what he is to teach." — Jerome, *Letter 53**

This means: study before you speak. Learn before you teach.

Big Idea

If you want to understand something deeply, you have to go to the source. For the Bible, that meant three languages. But languages are just tools. What matters most is the kind of person you are while you use them — humble, careful, and honest.

Try This

1. **Learn a New Alphabet.** Ask a grown-up to help you find the Hebrew or Greek alphabet online. Try writing your name in one of them. That is what Jerome did — but for a whole language.
2. **Three Words for One Thing.** Think of a word in English. Find its translation in two other languages. Do the words feel the same, or does each carry a slightly different feeling?
3. **Tool and Person.** Think of a tool you are good at using. Now imagine someone who is great with the tool but is mean to other players. Does the tool matter more, or does the way you treat people matter more?

Ask a Grown-Up

If you could learn any language in the world, which would you choose? What would you want to read or say in that language? Has knowing another language ever changed how you understood something?

Chapter 5: The Scholar in the Cave — Jerome's Desert Adventure



Illustration for Chapter 5

Around the year 374, Jerome did something unusual. He left the busy, cultured world of Rome and traveled to the Syrian desert. He joined a community of people who lived simply, prayed, fasted, and devoted themselves to God. He lived in a cave. He ate plain food. He studied.

Why would someone leave the greatest city in the world for a cave in the desert?

For Jerome, the desert was not an escape from learning. It was a place to reshape his learning in service of his faith. The desert was a classroom. And in that cave, Jerome began the hardest part of his education: he started learning Hebrew.

His teacher was a Jewish man whose name we do not know. The setting was harsh. No comfortable library, no fellow students, no textbooks. Just manuscripts, a teacher, and long hours of study. The same simplicity that shaped his prayer life shaped his scholarship.

Something else happened in the desert that became one of the most famous stories about Jerome. He described it years later in a letter. He had been reading Cicero — the great Roman writer whose elegant style Jerome had loved since his school days. He found himself preferring Cicero's beautiful sentences to the plain style of the Bible. The prophets did not sound like Cicero. The Gospels lacked rhetorical polish.

Then, he said, he had a dream. In the dream, he was brought before God's judgment seat. God asked him who he was. Jerome said, "A Christian." God answered: "You lie. You are a Ciceronian, not a Christian." And Jerome was scourged.

When he woke, he said he could still see the marks on his body. He vowed to stop reading pagan books and to devote his learning entirely to Scripture.

People have debated this dream for centuries. Was it a real experience? Or was it a story Jerome told to make a point? The truth may be somewhere in between. He may have had a powerful dream or illness, and he may have shaped the story later to express a real inner conflict. The dream captures something true about Jerome: he loved classical literature, and he felt that love competing with his love of Scripture. He resolved not to abandon his learning but to redirect it. Cicero would serve Christ.

But here is something important: Jerome never actually stopped using the classics. His later writings are full of quotes from Virgil, Horace, Cicero, and other Roman writers. He wrote in a classically trained style. A person who truly hated classical literature would not have written like that. What Jerome criticized was not the literature itself but the danger of loving it more than truth. A parent who tells a child not to spend all day playing a game does not hate the game. Jerome warned against letting classical literature push out the Bible.

The desert years taught Jerome something that stayed with him for life: serious study requires discipline. A mind distracted by luxury, ambition, or restlessness cannot attend to ancient texts. Fasting, prayer, solitude, and self-control were not punishments. They were ways of clearing space for attention. The scholar's life and the monk's life were the same life.

This idea shaped medieval monasticism for a thousand years. Benedictine monks divided their days between prayer, manual labor, and reading. The reading was not recreation. It was *lectio divina*, sacred reading. The monk who studied Scripture was doing something akin to prayer. Jerome's example made that way of life possible.

Jerome also knew that learning could feed pride. A scholar who mastered three languages could easily look down on those who knew less. Asceticism was supposed to guard against this. If a man could fast and sleep on the ground, he should be able to accept correction. Jerome did not always succeed. But the ideal remained: learning should make the learner humble, not arrogant.

Words to Remember

*"I began now to feel a distaste for that holy and saving simplicity of the inspired Scriptures." — Jerome, *Letter 22**

This means: Jerome noticed that he preferred beautiful classical writing over the plain style of the Bible. That bothered him.

*"Let the student be possessed with a proper fear of God and not seek after the praises of men." — Jerome, *Letter 53**

This means: study with reverence, not to show off.

Big Idea

Jerome believed that learning and discipline go together. The desert was not an escape — it was a place to focus. He showed that the same habits that help you pray (quiet, simplicity, patience) also help you think. Learning should make you humble, not proud.

Try This

1. **Design a Study Day.** Jerome prayed, studied, worked, and rested. Design your own perfect day. How much time for reading, playing, resting, quiet? Draw it as a schedule.
2. **The Two Loves.** Think of two things you love. Can you love both? What happens if one starts pushing out the other? Write one sentence about how you would keep balance.
3. **Focus Experiment.** Try to read a book for ten minutes with no interruptions. Then try it with interruptions. Which way did you understand more?

Ask a Grown-Up

Do you think you learn better when you are calm and quiet, or when you are busy and distracted? What helps you focus? What makes it harder?

Chapter 6: Old Wine and New — Jerome and the Problem of Change



Illustration for Chapter 6

Imagine your family has a recipe that has been passed down for generations. Every Thanksgiving, your grandmother makes it the same way. But one day you discover that the recipe has a mistake in it. The original recipe, written by your great-great-grandmother, says one tablespoon of sugar. Somewhere along the way, someone wrote one cup of sugar. The dish has been too sweet for fifty years, and no one noticed.

What should you do? Fix it? Or keep making it the wrong way because that is how everyone expects it to taste?

This is the problem Jerome faced with the Bible.

By his time, the Western church had inherited many Latin Bibles. They had been copied and recopied for generations. They were not identical. Some were clear; some were confusing. Some had mistakes that had been passed along for centuries. But these Old Latin versions were loved. People had prayed with them. They had memorized verses from them. They had heard sermons based on them. The familiar words had become sacred through use.

Jerome wanted to fix the mistakes. He believed that the original text of Scripture was the true tradition, and that later corruptions — whether from careless copyists or well-meaning revisers — had distorted it. He saw himself not as an innovator but as a restorer. He was recovering the original, not inventing something new.

His argument had several steps. The oldest source is the most authoritative — for the Old Testament, that meant Hebrew. Manuscripts accumulate errors over time. Restoration is not innovation. And accuracy serves the church: a Bible that says what the original said is more useful than a Bible that preserves familiar mistakes.

But tradition has power, and tradition has reasons to resist change. If the Bible changes, people may worry that the faith itself is changing. Worship depends on memory — prayers, songs, and readings are tied to specific words. New translations disrupt these memories. Authority is distributed: bishops, councils, and local communities have authority over what is read in church. And even a learned scholar can be wrong. How does a community know whether a proposed correction is genuine restoration or personal preference?

Augustine raised many of these concerns. He did not deny that Jerome's Hebrew-based translation might be better. He worried about how it would be received. He worried about ordinary believers hearing a familiar text changed and wondering whether the church had changed its faith.

Jerome's answer was simple, and perhaps too simple. He acknowledged that people dislike new translations. He simply believed that truth was worth the disruption:

"I am not so foolish as to think that any one can drink old wine and straightway desire new; nor that the ear accustomed to one mode of speech will not be offended at another. But I am confident that the truth, when it is once known, will please all who love learning."

The sentence shows both his realism and his confidence. He knows change is hard. He believes it is necessary anyway.

The tension between tradition and reform appears everywhere, not just in Bible translation. Scientists challenge established theories. Historians revise accepted narratives. Artists break with old conventions. Each case raises the same questions: When does fidelity to the past become obstruction? When does innovation become disregard?

Jerome's example suggests that the best reformers are those who love what they criticize. He did not despise the Bible; he wanted it to be as true as possible. He did not despise the church; he wanted it to have the best text. A reformer who hates the tradition he seeks to reform usually destroys more than he fixes. A reformer who loves the tradition may anger people, but he has a better chance of serving them.

Jerome was not always wise about the speed and manner of change. He sometimes treated every opponent as an enemy of truth. He underestimated the pastoral value of continuity. He could be contemptuous of people who needed time to adjust. A balanced view would include both his insight — correct error when you find it — and Augustine's caution — introduce correction with patience and care for the community.

Neither alone is enough. You need both: love of the tradition enough to correct it when it is wrong, and love of the community enough to do it gently.

Words to Remember

"I am confident that the truth, when it is once known, will please all who love learning." — Jerome, to Augustine

This means: Jerome knew people resist change, but he believed truth would win them over eventually.

*"What have I done? I have translated... restored it to its original form." — Jerome,
*Against Rufinus**

This means: Jerome did not see himself as making something new. He saw himself as fixing what had been broken.

Big Idea

Change is hard. People love what is familiar, even when it has mistakes. Jerome believed that fixing mistakes was worth the discomfort. But he sometimes forgot that people need time to adjust. The best reformers love the tradition enough to correct it — and love the community enough to be patient.

Try This

1. **The Recipe Fix.** Imagine the family recipe story from the beginning of this chapter. What would you say to your grandmother to convince her to fix it? How would you say it kindly?
2. **Old and New.** Think of something at your school or home that has "always been done a certain way." Is there a reason for the tradition? Could it be better? Write one sentence for keeping it and one for changing it.
3. **The Patient Reformer.** Think of a time you wanted to change something and people resisted. Did you push harder, or did you try to help them understand? Which worked better?

Ask a Grown-Up

Have you ever wanted to change something that had been done the same way for a long time? What happened? Did people listen, or did they resist? What would you do differently now?

For the Grown-Up Reader

This booklet introduces children to Jerome (c. 347–420 CE), the biblical scholar who produced the Latin Vulgate. The stories are simplified but grounded in real history. The quotes are Jerome's own words, drawn from his prefaces, letters, and commentaries, translated into plain English for young readers.

Primary sources used: - *Preface to the Gospels (Praefatio in Evangeliiis)* — "I have interpreted not word for word, but sense for sense." - *Preface to the Psalter (Praefatio in Psalterio)* — the defense of Hebrew-based translation. - *Commentary on Matthew (Commentariorum in Matthaeum)* — the sun-shines example. - *Letter 22* (to Eustochium) — the Ciceronian crisis and the desert experience. - *Letter 53* (to Paulinus of Nola) — the three-language ideal. - *Against Rufinus (Apologia contra Rufinum)* — defending his translation method. - Correspondence with Augustine — the tradition vs. reform debate.

Secondary sources consulted: J.N.D. Kelly, *Jerome: His Life, Writings, and Controversies* (Duckworth, 1975); Stefan Rebenich, *Jerome* (Routledge, 2002); Adam Kamesar, *Jerome*,

Greek Scholarship, and the Hebrew Bible (Oxford, 1993). These are the standard scholarly works on Jerome's life and methods.

A note on the Ciceronian dream: The dream described in Chapter 5 is one of the most debated passages in Jerome's corpus. Scholars disagree about whether it was a literal experience or a literary construction. The booklet presents it as Jerome told it, without insisting on one reading. Children can understand the dream as a story about choosing what matters most, regardless of whether every detail was factual.

A note on Jerome's temperament: Chapter 3 presents Jerome's sharpness honestly. The booklet does not excuse his cruelty, but it also does not reduce him to it. Jerome was a real, complicated person — brilliant, difficult, tender, and proud, sometimes all in the same letter. Children can begin to understand that gifted people are not always easy people, and that being right does not excuse being unkind.

A note on anti-Judaism: Jerome's relationship with Jewish teachers and with Judaism was complex. He learned from Jewish scholars and preserved valuable Jewish traditions, but he also wrote polemically against Jewish interpretation. This topic is too complex for the elementary level and is addressed in the older age bands.

All quotes in this booklet are real. They have been simplified in wording but not in meaning. Where Jerome's language was combative, the booklet says so. Where it was tender, the booklet preserves the tenderness. The goal is to let children meet Jerome as a person, not a legend.

About WisdomForge

WisdomForge creates age-adapted booklets that bring the great thinkers of history to readers from five years old to adulthood. Each figure gets four booklets — one for elementary ages (5–10), one for middle school (11–14), one for high school (15–18), and one for adult readers. The same person, the same ideas, shaped for how you read and think at each stage of life. We believe that the questions people asked a thousand years ago are still worth asking today — and that a child can begin to ask them just as honestly as a scholar can. Read it. Question it. Discuss it. Do it.